

JOHN AMPONG

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EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

University of South Carolina 2022–Present
Ph.D. in Business Administration, Concentration in Finance

Xiamen University 2018–2020
Master of Applied Economics in Financial Engineering

University of Cape Coast 2013–2017
Bachelor of Management Studies (Hons.)

WORKING PAPERS

Changing the Subject: How Managerial Attention Reallocation Obscures Bad News (JMP)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** AI in Finance Conference (2026 scheduled), Brownbag Seminar, University of South Carolina (2026)

I propose a measure of managerial attention reallocation from a manager's own historical baseline, constructed using BERTopic applied to earnings call transcripts from 2007 to 2023. I find that unusual attention reallocation predicts negative abnormal returns, elevated crash risk over horizons up to two years, persistently lower long-run returns, greater analyst forecast dispersion, and elevated options market jump risk. It further predicts a significant rise in bad-news mandatory disclosures and adverse incidents in subsequent months. Markets and analysts consistently fail to extract this signal at the time of the call, suggesting that strategic redirection of managerial attention obscures deteriorating fundamentals in plain sight.

Can a Shareholder Focus Create Value for all Stakeholders? (with Matthew Souther)

- **Media Coverage:** *The Columbia Law School Blue Sky Blog* (June 10, 2025)
- **Conferences and Seminars:** Georgia State – Management Science AI & FinTech Conference (2025), Financial Management Association (2025), Southern Finance Association (2025), RCF-ECGI Corporate Finance and Governance Conference (2026 scheduled)
- **Awards:** *Best Paper Award* (Darla Moore School Business)

We develop a novel machine-learning technique analyzing earnings call transcripts to measure whether a manager's focus is on shareholders or external stakeholders. We find that managers focusing on shareholders generate significantly higher stock returns in subsequent periods. However, these higher returns do not come to the detriment of other stakeholders; we find that shareholder-focused firms experience far fewer adverse environmental and social incidents, and those that do occur are less severe. Using natural disasters as an instrument for managerial focus and exploiting exogenous shifts in firm orientation induced by CEO transitions, we find that a shareholder focus causally reduces adverse E&S outcomes across all horizons examined. We conclude that a shareholder-focused strategy creates maximum value for both shareholders and stakeholders.

Selective Attention: Do Mutual Fund Incentives Affect their Voting? (with Matthew Souther)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** Financial Management Association (2025), Southern Finance Association (2025), Global Finance Conference(2025)
- **Awards:** *First Year Paper Award*

In a sample of ballot items for which proxy advisor recommendations oppose management, we find that the likelihood of a mutual fund actively voting (deviating from proxy advisor recommendations) is significantly higher when the fund has larger monetary incentives tied to the portfolio holding. To address endogenous portfolio selection issues, we find the same result in a sample of passive index funds for which portfolio allocations are exogenous. Firms that are more commonly held by less incentivized funds have lower CEO delta and lower CEO turnover-performance sensitivity.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Managerial Tax Attention and Corporate Tax Outcomes (with Jason DeBacker)

We construct a measure of corporate tax attention from the text of quarterly earnings calls for U.S. public firms over 2007 to 2023 using an unsupervised topic model. The measure captures within-firm deviations in tax attention from the firm's own historical same-quarter baseline. We find that elevated tax attention predicts lower cash effective tax rates over horizons of up to three years and generates positive announcement returns. A triple difference-in-differences design exploiting the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act of 2017 shows that firms with high pre-reform tax attention and high effective tax rates captured the largest post-reform reductions. Analysts revise earnings forecasts upward and realized earnings subsequently exceed their revised forecasts, consistent with partial incorporation of a signal that is available but costly to extract.

The Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) from the Small Business Perspective: Did the PPP Help Alleviate Financial and Economic Constraints? (with Allen N. Berger, Paul G. Freed, Zheyu Qi, Jonathan A. Scott, and Siwen Zhang)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** Southern Finance Association(2022)*, Financial Management Association(2022)*, Temple University*, University of South Carolina*

We employ two novel datasets to evaluate whether the Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) met short-term and longer-term goals. One dataset matches PPP with small business members of the National Federation of Business (NFIB) that report their financial constraints and their employees' economic constraints. We find more alleviation of both constraints for PPP recipients, consistent with short-term goals. We employ data on post- versus pre-crisis county employment, wages, and new businesses to test the longer-term goal of improved community crisis recoveries from the short-term constraint relief. We find to the contrary – worse longer-term recoveries in counties with more short-term constraint relief.

Who Do You Trust?: Evidence from Mutual Fund Managers Allocation Decision (with Omrane Guedhami and Sadok El Ghoul)

Preliminary results documented

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Empirical Corporate Finance, Corporate Governance, Shareholder Voting, ESG, Machine Learning in Finance

RESEARCH AND TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant

Prof. Matthew Souther, University of South Carolina	2023–Present
Prof. Gregory R. Niehaus, University of South Carolina	2022
Prof. Chen Haiqiang, Xiamen University	2019

Instructor/Teaching Assistant

Instructor of Record, Corporate Finance, University of South Carolina	<i>Fall 2025</i>
Investment Analysis and Portfolio Management, University of South Carolina	<i>2023, 2024</i>
Financial Statement Analysis, University of South Carolina	<i>2022</i>
Financial Economics, Xiamen University	<i>2019</i>
Quantitative Methods in Finance, University of Cape Coast	<i>2017</i>
Financial Management, University of Cape Coast	<i>2017</i>

CORPORATE EXPERIENCE

Internship, National Investment Bank, Kumasi, Ghana	<i>2016</i>
Internship, CSIR-Building and Road Research Institute, Kumasi, Ghana	<i>2015</i>

SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

Doctoral Fellows Award for Outstanding Academic & Research Performance	<i>2026, 2025</i>
University of South Carolina, Graduate School Travel Grant	<i>2025</i>
Best Second Year Paper Award, University of South Carolina	<i>2024</i>
First Year Paper Award, University of South Carolina	<i>2023</i>
Business Administration Scholarship, University of South Carolina	<i>2022, 2023, 2024</i>
Excellent International Student Award, Xiamen University	<i>2020</i>
Chinese Government Scholarship, Xiamen University	<i>2018</i>
Scholarship for First Class Students, ICA, Ghana	<i>2017</i>
Dean's Awards for High Academic Performance, University of Cape Coast	<i>2015, 2016, 2017</i>

SERVICE

Reviewer, Eastern Finance Association (EFA)	<i>2025</i>
Reviewer, Southern Finance Association (SFA)	<i>2025</i>
Discussant, FMA, SFA	<i>2025</i>
Brown Bag Coordinator, Darla Moore, Finance Department	<i>2024–Present</i>
Ph.D. students recruitment assistant, Darla Moore, Finance Department	<i>2024</i>
Student Assistant, WISE-SOE international students, Xiamen University	<i>2019</i>
Co-Organizer and Speaker, WISE-SOE International Students Orientation	<i>2019</i>
Head of the Finance Committee, UCC Association of Business Students	<i>2016</i>

MAJOR CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS ATTENDED

AI in Finance Conference	<i>(scheduled)</i>
RCF-ECGI Corporate Finance and Governance Conference	<i>(scheduled)</i>
Georgia State – <i>Management Science</i> AI & FinTech Conference	<i>2025</i>
Financial Management Association(FMA) Vancouver, Canada	<i>2025</i>

Southern Finance Association(SFA) Conference Florida, USA	<i>2025</i>
SFS Cavalcade North America, New Jersey, USA	<i>2025</i>
32nd Annual Global Finance Conference, Boston Massachusetts, USA	<i>2025</i>
SFS Cavalcade North America, Atlanta-Georgia, USA	<i>2024</i>
Frontiers in International Finance Conference, South Carolina	<i>2024</i>
FMA Conference, Atlanta-Georgia, USA	<i>2022</i>
Fixed Income and Financial Institution Conference, South Carolina	<i>2022–2024</i>
Asian Meeting of the Econometric Society, Xiamen University, China	<i>2019</i>
Bank of America Merrill Lynch Summer Program, University of Ghana	<i>2017</i>

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Machine Learning, Python, SAS, Stata, R, SLURM, L^AT_EX

INTERESTS AND HOBBIES

Teaching, soccer, country music

REFERENCES

Professor Matthew Souther
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